Good morning, respected Principal Ma'am, teachers, and my dear friends.

I'm Ansh of Class 9th Daisy. Today, I stand before you to speak on a topic that might sound unusual, but I believe it is something we all need to think about.

If I may, allow me to pose a rather unsettling question.

What if the dream you are chasing is not actually yours?

Ever since we took our first breath in this world, we have been spoon-fed ideas of what success should look like. Study hard, secure good grades, enter a prestigious college, get a respectable job, and eventually settle down.

And there is nothing inherently wrong with any of these things.

But let's be honest. Times have changed. Inflation is rising, college education can cost lakhs of rupees, and a degree alone no longer guarantees a successful career. We spend years preparing for entrance examinations, invest heavily in coaching, and sacrifice our interests to enter institutions like the IITs. Yet, even a prestigious degree cannot guarantee employment, let alone job security.

So, are we questioning the destination, or are we simply following the crowd?

More than two thousand years ago, the Greek philosopher Plato described prisoners chained inside a cave. They could see only shadows on a wall, and because those shadows were all they had ever known, they mistook them for reality.

My dear friends, what if some of our dreams are nothing more than shadows on a wall?

What if we are so busy trying to become the best in a system that we have never questioned whether that system is right for us?

Consider Roy Lee, co-founder of Cluely, who faced suspension from Columbia University after developing an AI tool with his co-founder. Rather than treating the conventional academic path as his only route to success, he continued building his startup.

Then there is Zach Yadegari, co-founder of Cal AI. Despite being rejected by fifteen of the eighteen universities he applied to, he built a successful business that was eventually acquired by MyFitnessPal.

Their stories do not prove that college is useless or that rejection guarantees success. They demonstrate something far more important: there is more than one path to achievement.

And that is precisely my point.

I am not here to tell you what to pursue. I am asking you to rethink what you have been taught to pursue.

Question your ambitions. Examine your assumptions. And have the courage to change direction when you discover that the destination was never truly yours.

Because a dream should be a direction, not a prison.

And perhaps the greatest achievement is not reaching the destination everyone celebrates, but having the courage to choose your own.

Thank you, and have a wonderful day.